

Existential Coaching

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INTRODUCTION

All human beings share various existential qualities or 'givens' of existence: we experience our existence through our bodies and within conditions of time and space; we struggle with and are sustained by the possibilities and limitations of the meanings we construe about any and every facet of our lives; and we maintain hopes and plans and expectations within the uncertainty and insecurity of lives whose inevitable movement is towards death. At the same time, *how* each of us gives expression to these 'givens' remains unique (Cohn, 1997; Jacobsen, 2007).

Existential coaching explores the primary concerns of coaching – namely, those matters related to professional, managerial and leadership development and performance – from the perspective of the above givens as expressed and lived by individual clients, be they persons or organizations. In general, it is concerned with the life dilemmas that arise as a consequence of changes and circumstances in a broadly organizational context and which impact upon personal and interpersonal relations both within that context and beyond it.

Existential coaching is best understood and practised as a predominantly descriptively focused investigative enterprise. Rather than be primarily concerned with the alteration, reduction, removal or resolution of presenting concerns, existential theory suggests that the coach's principal task is to assist clients in focusing upon their presenting concerns in ways that contextualize them more adequately, within their *worldview* – which is to say, the whole range of beliefs, values, attitudes, assumptions, affects and behaviours that make up, maintain and identify their 'way of being'. Further, existential coaching proposes that clients' concerns are not to be seen as obstacles to the maintenance of the current worldview, but rather as consequential

expressions of it. From this perspective, therefore, the issues brought to coaching cannot be dealt with as separate from the whole being who presents them.

Overall, existential coaching adopts a position that is well summarized by the coaching theorist, Peter Bluckert: ‘Many ... coaches begin with a strong tendency to look for the solution to the client’s problem in the external reality – the outer game. They eagerly race towards a practical set of actions before fully understanding the complexities of the issue in the first place’ (Bluckert, 2006: 48). As this chapter will seek to clarify, existential coaching contributes to the development of the profession by illuminating many of these complexities and providing coaches with various means with which to work, in ways that may best benefit their clients.

KEY ASSUMPTIONS OF EXISTENTIAL THEORY

Existential theory has no single founder or authoritative source (Yalom, 1980; Cooper, 2003). Nonetheless, its multitude of manifestations agree upon a number of key foundational principles. As has been argued elsewhere (Spinelli, 2007), three of these principles are pivotal in delineating existential theory’s stance toward the human condition and, as well, are particularly pertinent to existential coaching practice.

a. Relatedness

At its simplest, the principle of relatedness argues that all attempts to understand or make sense of any being – ourselves included – on its own or in isolation is far too limiting and inadequate. Rather, all beings express themselves through and are shaped by an interrelational grounding or context. All beings are always *beings-in-relation*.

Existential theory’s stance toward the principle of relatedness challenges a persistent assumption held by Western culture in general: that the person is a self-contained unit, understandable within his or her own set of subjectively-derived meanings and behaviours. From the standpoint of relatedness, the problems and concerns presented by coaching clients can no longer be seen as being solely their own, in any exclusively individualistic sense. Our particular ways of relating impact upon all other ways of relating and *vice versa*.

In sum, from an existential perspective, human existence reveals ‘the total, indissoluble unity or interrelationship of the individual and his or her world ... in the truest sense, the person is viewed as having no existence apart from the world and the world as having no existence apart from persons’ (Valle & King, 1978: 7).

b. Uncertainty

The second principle espoused by existential theory argues that if all of one’s reflective experience and knowledge of self, others and the world in general arises through and within

relatedness, then what is revealed is an inevitable and inescapable *uncertainty* or incompleteness in any and all of our reflections.

This uncertainty is not just about the realization that the unexpected can and does occur in our lives. Rather, uncertainty also permeates what appears as the predictable or habitual in our lives. We can never fully know with complete and final certainty what and how the world will be, or others will be, or even ‘I’ will be, in any given set of circumstances. At any moment, any and every aspect or dispositional quality that makes up a being’s worldview may be opened to challenge, reconsideration or dissolution. Common statements such as ‘I never thought I would act like that’, or ‘she seemed to turn into someone I didn’t know’, or ‘I just can’t make sense of what’s going on in the world any longer’ point us to positions that at least temporarily acknowledge the inevitable uncertainties of being.

c. *Existential anxiety*

Existential theory argues that humans are ‘meaning-making’ beings. We *interpret* the world via the human process of constructing meaning of those ‘things’ or events which impinge themselves upon our experience and with which we are in relation. However, if all of our meaning-making is both relationally-derived and uncertain, then it becomes evident that no meanings we construe can ever be said to be final, complete or closed to further possibility. Instead, because they always remain open to the possibility of novel definitions, all our attempts at meaning-making ultimately confront their definitional openness or *meaninglessness*.

Existential anxiety refers first to the uneasy experience accompanying the awareness of the ultimate incompleteness or openness of all our meanings – including, of course, all of those meanings that serve to define and maintain ‘the self’. Second, existential anxiety also refers to the inevitable unease and insecurity that arises when we attempt either to deny, or claim to have resolved, the dilemma of meaning – not least, for example when we ‘capture’ self (and other) into fixed categories, typologies, characteristics and the like.

Existential theory argues that anxiety permeates *all* reflective experience. However, rather than being only or necessarily a debilitating, disruptive or problematic presence that must be reduced or removed, this anxiety can also be stimulating, can put us in touch with our sense of being alive, and is the source to all creative and original insight and decision making. The dilemma raised by existential anxiety is not so much *that* it is, but rather *how* each of us ‘lives with’ it.

Taken together, these three basic principles give shape to a view of human development that, unlike many others adopted by coaches, rejects any simple uni-directional perspective or ‘growth-model’. Instead, it places human beings within a far more open-ended – and hence uncertain – trajectory whose focus and direction cannot be set or maintained by the individual alone. Rather, what developmental possibilities emerge are always sourced within an interrelational context, remain uncertain and will always provoke some felt sense of unease.

ESSENTIAL PROCESSES AND DYNAMICS

Following on from the above summary of its key principles, it can be seen that existential theory highlights the human experience of an ever-present tension between certainty and uncertainty, between the demand for a fixed and final truth and being 'true to' what presents itself to our lived experience. One useful way to explore this tension is through the polarity of *meaning* and *meaninglessness*.

As was proposed above, a primary characteristic of being human is that we are meaning-making beings. Our encounters with the unknown or uncertain – or broadly speaking, with what is labelled initially as meaningless – provoke the quest to discern (or construct) their meaning (Spinelli, 2005, 2007). Equally, we typically protect ourselves against instances of, or confrontations with, meaninglessness, by adopting rigid stances toward – or *sedimenting* – many of our lived meanings so that they become inflexible 'truths' or dogmas impervious to experiential data that may challenge or contradict them. Each one of us develops a 'life project' (Sartre, 1956) – which includes our goals, our values, our ways of understanding and responding to the expected and the unexpected in our lives – that reveals how, as individuals, we have found means to 'navigate' our way through the inevitable polarity of meaning/meaninglessness.

The worldview can be seen to be a dynamic expression of this life project in that it reflects and contains our attempts to come to terms with polarities such as meaning/meaninglessness. Just as the meaning components of the worldview provide us with the experience of security, certainty, stability, identity and predictability, the worldview possibilities of change, growth and novel possibilities can only occur through our openness toward meaninglessness. Tensions between meaning and meaninglessness can be disturbing and debilitating. However, they are also the means to our creativity, discovery, playfulness and imagination.

If we think of meaning/meaninglessness as complementary end-points along a continuum, each of us can 'locate' him or herself at some point along that continuum. One way of considering the dilemmas presented by coaching clients is to view them as life challenges that have provoked a location disturbance along a polarity continuum (May, 1994). This (usually) temporary sense of dislocation can be experienced as either stimulating or disquieting. Those challenges that we experience as stimulating suggest our willingness to dislocate ourselves from a particular point in our existential continuum and to explore those possibilities that are likely to lead to some sort of relocation. Alternatively, those challenges that provoke increasing levels of disquiet and disorder suggest that the person's response to existential dislocation is one that seeks to avoid or deny that challenge and thereby return or remain at the point in the continuum where he or she currently locates him or herself.

Considering this stance from a coaching standpoint, what on the surface may appear to be the same source of challenge, conflict or disturbance for a person or an organization may not actually be so, since it is only by considering the relationship between that challenge and any particular worldview that the specific impact of that challenge can be discerned.

All challenges threaten the security brought about by having placed oneself along the continuum of a currently-maintained polarity. Existential theory argues that in order for the coach to assist clients as adequately as possible, it is critical to clarify just how that sense of security has been disturbed and what sort of disturbing impact is being experienced by the client's worldview.

For example in some instances the client's presenting issues arise from challenges to the worldview that reflect a gap or *dissonance* between one or several rigid or sedimented meanings and the actual experiences of being that disconfirm, or contradict those meaning stances. For example:

- a) Arthur insists that he is a team player and an excellent listener, but has been confronted with statements from his team that present him as a bully who is often uninterested in views and concerns raised by others.
- b) An organization presents itself as a leader in change but is deeply resistant to novel possibilities in management.

The above examples reveal dissonances between sedimented meanings and lived experience. From the focus point of meaning/meaninglessness, they reveal a dislocation along that polarity. This disturbance can only be adequately resolved through relocation along the continuum. Dynamically speaking, this involves a temporary step into meaninglessness so that a more adequate and effective meaning might emerge. For example:

- a) Arthur accepts that his view of himself as always being a team player and an excellent listener is inadequate. Instead, it is more accurate for him to state that he would like to be so and that in the eyes of others he can be seen to be quite the opposite.
- b) The organization acknowledges that its view of itself as a leader in change is currently inadequate and sets about reorganizing its management structure so that it is more in keeping with its philosophy.

However, coaching issues may arise under a second, and quite differing, set of circumstances. In this case, the experience of existential dislocation is provoked by challenges that are *consonant* with the client's continuum location. Rather than reveal a lack of fit, or tension, between contradictory or competing meaning-derived stances, the source of disturbance lies in unexpected or undesired expressions of previously unforeseen or insufficiently considered consequences of the currently-maintained worldview. For example:

- a) Joanna insists that she is always blunt and honest in her corporate evaluations, and this makes her feel alone, isolated and unappreciated by others.
- b) An organization presents itself as a leader in change and this limits the number of desirable managers who will work well within it or who are willing to remain associated with it.

The above examples reveal a tension that arises within a meaning stance that 'fits' or is consonant with the worldview. In other words, the presenting issues *arise from* or are consequential expressions of having located oneself along a particular continuum. From the focus point of meaning/meaninglessness, they reveal unexpected or undesired consequences of maintaining,

or being consonant with, a particular location along that polarity. This disturbance cannot be properly resolved through relocation along the continuum. Rather, what is required is a temporary step into meaninglessness that will permit the acceptance of previously unconsidered, unexpected and uneasy consequences that emerge simply by locating oneself along a polarity continuum. For example:

- a) Joanna realizes that she places a critical value upon her blunt honesty, and while this does not alter her experience of aloneness, isolation, lack of appreciation by others, she discovers a resoluteness that she did not previously appreciate.
- b) The organization explores its own attitude to change by investigating what it is about its identity, ethos or structure that may be hampering its quest for suitable managers. In doing so, it adjusts the various ways by which it seeks out suitable managers.

Existential coaching argues that it is essential to discern whether any client's presenting issues reveal either dissonant or consonant tensions, since each expresses quite differing concerns. This difference is missed by many coaches who tend to assume that their clients' issues are always and only expressions of dissonance. As a consequence, their interventions may, at best, be unhelpful and, at worst, may provoke far greater disturbances for their clients.

In addition, through its assumption of a foundational interrelatedness, existential theory argues that it is important for coaches to recognize that a change in any *one* aspect of the worldview will alter the *whole* of it (Ihde, 1986; Spinelli, 2005). As such, the consequences of any step taken toward the resolution of either dissonant or consonant issues cannot be known in advance. What we do know is that what might appear in theory to be a minor shift can have dramatic repercussions that may well be undesirable, unexpected and ultimately more debilitating than the initial presenting conflict. For example:

- a) Armand realizes that he has always had great difficulty in developing a close friendship bond with other men. Through coaching, he decides to alter this and joins an 'Iron John' type men's group. In doing so, he achieves his desired goal but also experiences unexpected consequences. He finds himself sexually attracted to a number of men with whom he has become close. How will this affect Armand's marriage? How will it affect Armand's sense of himself in terms of sexual orientation? Or his sense of himself in general? How will it affect his relations with his wife? His children? His friends?
- b) An organization decides that it is time to change its logo. It does so and is satisfied with the predicted results in that the logo provokes positive perceptions both within the organization and from its customer base with regard to various desirable identifying features. At the same time, however, such shifts in perception have an unexpected and not always desirable impact. For instance, they extend to ways in which management meetings are conducted, in employees' sense of belonging to and responsibility for the organization and in the rise of different demands and expectations from its customer base.

Such examples, which are by no means unusual, highlight existential theory's advocacy of coaches adopting a cautious stance in their desire, or indeed, insistence, to promote change. Once again, any coach-directed tampering with the presenting issues without sufficiently understanding their relatedness to the client's worldview might well create far greater distress and unease in living than did the original presenting problem.

ROLE OF THE EXISTENTIAL COACH IN THE COACHING RELATIONSHIP

Overall, the existential coach's primary role lies in the attempt to *be with* and *be for* the client. In *being with* the client, existential coaches seek to give expression to their respect for, and acceptance of, their client's worldview as it presents itself in their current encounter. In *being for* their clients, existential coaches express their willingness to attempt a challenging, non-judgmental descriptively-focused exploration of that worldview.

In this dual aim, they seek first to disclose, together with their client, the underlying, often implicit and inadequately acknowledged values, beliefs, assumptions, attitudinal stances and their accompanying affective and behavioural components which infuse and maintain the client's worldview. And second, through such explorations, they attempt to illuminate the present-ing concerns and issues within the context of that worldview, so that whatever it may be that is being challenged, of or within that worldview, can be clarified and considered.

At the heart of this enterprise lies the attempt to ensure their clients' experience of 'being heard' accurately so that in turn clients may begin to hear their own statements more accurately and honestly. This predominantly receptive stance requires on the part of the coach the abdication of such security that comes with assumptions such as directing change or of 'the expert's' superiority of knowledge and status. Further, the adoption of this stance and attitude removes from coaches much of their professional mystique as well as a good deal of the power that may come with it.

For many coaches, this aspect of existential coaching is likely to be deeply challenging. Rather than focus upon the wisdom of knowledge and authority, the wisdom associated with existential coaching can be seen to be that of *un-knowing* (Spinelli, 1997, 2007). Un-knowing refers to that attempt on the part of the coach to remain as open as possible to that, and only that, which presents itself in the relationship. As such, it expresses the attempt to treat the seemingly familiar, assumed to be understood or understandable, as novel, unfixed in meaning, and, hence, accessible to previously unexamined possibilities. The attempt to 'un-know' directs both the coach's and the client's primary focus to remain on 'what is there' as opposed to 'what once might have been there' or 'what may one day be there'. Further, it challenges the technical authority of the coach as well as the client's own demands to be the recipient of that authority.

Although the stance of un-knowing adopted by existential coaching may, for some coaches, seem unusual or even antithetical to the coaching enterprise, recent views expressed by coaches from differing traditions are in close agreement. For example Graham Lee, an expert in leadership coaching, has written that 'the creation of a learning space depends on a particular quality of the coach that we might describe as "not knowing" ... the coach's capacity for openness, reflection, questioning, wondering and entertaining possibilities ... a willingness to stay with the uncertainties without reaching prematurely for fact or reason' (Lee, 2003: 63).

In adopting this stance of un-knowing, the whole focus of existential coaching centres upon what is taking place *directly* between coach and client. This focus serves to expose and clarify *in the immediacy of the current coaching relationship* the self-same interrelational issues that clients experience within their wider world relations. In other words, from the standpoint of

existential theory, the coaching relationship is seen to be the ‘microcosm’ which both explores and expresses the ‘macrocosm’ of the client’s currently-lived experience (Cohn, 1997; Spinelli, 1997, 2001; Strasser & Strasser, 1997). This view is only just beginning to be addressed by coaching in general. Coaches have tended to be somewhat reluctant, if not unwilling, to bring explicitly this key assumption within existential coaching into their discourse and interventions with their clients. Nonetheless, this reluctance in focusing upon those factors that highlight the immediacy of the coaching relationship has recently been challenged by the coaching theorist, Peter Bluckert, who has written: ‘the very dynamics occurring in the coaching relationship may be a mirror image of clients’ experiences in their workplace relationships and they may be completely unaware of it’ (Bluckert, 2006: 48).

TASKS AND GOALS OF EXISTENTIAL COACHING

Unlike the majority of coaching perspectives that focus upon broadly positive, self-actualizing possibilities for each client, existential coaching recognizes and gives equal emphasis to the divided stances, aims and aspirations that may well exist as competing values and beliefs held by them. In general, existential theory argues that the client’s experience of ‘what and how it is for me to exist’ is rarely entirely complete, coherent or consistent. Instead it reveals ‘a complex combination of opposites, some reconcilable, others incapable of being resolved or harmonised’ (Cherniss, 2006, as cited in Gray, 2006: 21).

While by no means dismissive of problem- or solution-focused interventions, existential coaching urges patience and caution in providing such without first considering the impacting concerns and issues being presented in relation to the specific worldview of the client. Not to do so might well generate unhelpful solutions that do not sufficiently address the primary concerns being raised for that particular client. Equally, although the solutions provided may well minimize or remove presenting problems, the very removal or reduction of such may bring to light far more disquieting concerns. In other words, presenting problems, issues and concerns are often ‘not just’ problems – they are also attempted solutions, whose purpose is to protect and maintain the worldview from far more disturbing challenges.

Paradoxically, existential coaching argues that beneficial change may best emerge via the very process of assisting clients to ‘stay still’ so that they can better explore, evaluate and come to terms with their currently-lived worldview and its experiential consequences.

METHODS AND TECHNIQUES FOR FACILITATION OF CHANGE

Existential coaching neither embraces nor dismisses any particular method or technique available to coaches so long as the technique serves the primary enterprise of a descriptively-focused exploration of the client’s worldview from the contextual focus of the client’s presenting

concerns. Nonetheless, this focus on descriptive exploration requires coaches to develop specific attitudes and skills designed to assist descriptively-focused enquiry. Two such approaches can be briefly summarized:

a) The phenomenological method

One particularly useful and powerful way to assist the coach in becoming attuned to the client's worldview as it expresses itself is to apply what has become known as *the phenomenological method* of investigation. This method can be most easily summarized by highlighting three pivotal 'steps' (Ihde, 1986; Spinelli, 2005, 2007).

Step one: Bracketing

This first step urges coaches to set aside their initial biases and prejudices, to suspend expectations and assumptions – in short, to *bracket* all presuppositions regarding the client as far as is possible. Instead, coaches are encouraged to attune their focus to 'what presents itself as it presents itself' so that the client's currently lived worldview can be more adequately disclosed and, in turn, so that any subsequent reconstructions of it will fit its meanings and values.

Step two: Description

The second step enjoins coaches to: 'describe, don't explain'. Rather than attempt to immediately analyse or transform the client's concerns on the basis of the coaches' preferred theories or hypotheses, the step of description urges them to remain initially focused on that information which arises from a concretely-based descriptive exploration of the client's worldview. The focus of this step centres more on the elaboration of the 'what and how' of a client's experience than it does on the explanation of its 'why'.

Step three: Horizontalization

The third step further advises coaches to avoid placing any unsubstantiated hierarchies of significance or importance upon the client's statements of experience, and instead to treat each as initially having equal value. It proposes that coaches avoid jumping to conclusions as to what really matters to the client or, indeed, what it may be that the client is seeking to address and resolve. In essence, horizontalization reminds coaches to treat the import and significance of all statements made by clients as being initially unknown to them.

Even from this very brief summary, it should be apparent that each 'step' in the phenomenological method is, more accurately, a particular point of focus rather than an entirely independent activity that can be wholly distinguished from the remaining two. Equally, any attempt to carry out the phenomenological method will reveal the impossibility of its fulfilment. Even so, while coaches may be unable to achieve complete bracketing, pure description or total horizontalization, they are certainly capable of attempting each with increasing adequacy and, by so doing, are likely to become more aware of any number of unintended and undesirable biases

that dominate their investigations. What is more, this self-same act of bias recognition can invoke for the coach a greater degree of caution in adhering too closely or uncritically to the immediate prejudices that he or she may have imposed upon the investigation from its earliest stages.

b) Descriptive questioning

An extension of the phenomenological method that has been proposed by the present author emphasizes a form of enquiry designed to clarify a client's experience from the standpoints of its *embodiment*, *metaphorical equivalence* and *narrational parallels* (Spinelli, 2007).

Viewed existentially, many statements made by clients regarding their experiences of someone or of some event (such as 'I'm depressed', 'I'm so angry', 'I'm not sure what to do' and so forth) *suggest* a clear and understandable meaning but are descriptively far too abstract and detached from the client's lived experience of them. Descriptive questioning provokes a more descriptively adequate set of statements regarding the experience and, by so doing, re-awakens their felt experience in the immediacy of the coaching relationship. In general, descriptive questioning concerns itself with the attempt to clarify clients' relations to their felt experience so that these are more adequately 'owned' by or accessible to them. A brief example should clarify each of these descriptive focus points.

Alice, a senior manager in an international organization, has come to coaching because she wants to explore future directions for her career. She states that she 'feels blocked' and can see nothing in her future that excites or stimulates her.

From the standpoint of *embodiment*, descriptive questioning assists Alice in locating her experience of 'feeling blocked', either in parts or the whole of her body. For instance: 'Where, if anywhere, in her body does she experience "feeling blocked"?' What, more precisely, is that feeling? What effect does it have upon the whole or parts of her body? Does it provoke particular statements and emotions?'

From the standpoint of *metaphorical equivalence*, descriptive questioning urges Alice to explore what the experience of 'feeling blocked' is *like* for her. For instance: 'If it were like a shape, an object, a sound, a colour, a song, a statement and so forth, what would it be?'

From the standpoint of *narrational parallels*, descriptive questioning encourages Alice to focus on stories or narratives from her own, or others' (including fictional others') lives that capture the experience 'feeling blocked' in order to bring a narrative focus to her attempts at description.

APPLICATION TO SPECIFIC COACHING CONTEXTS AND GENRES

It can be argued that the existential approach is amenable to every form of coaching, since all of the concerns relevant to coaching, from career and performance issues to matters of

leadership and managerial development or transformation, are most usefully explored when considered in relation to the specific context of a person's overall stance and outlook to self, others and life in general. Nonetheless, the approach is particularly useful when working with issues of transition or progression and advancement in work, where dilemmas are often about reconstituting identity, regaining meaning at work, or dealing with lost possibilities and legacy. In addition, existential coaching may be especially valuable when working with clients who find themselves at a crisis point in their lives, who have come up against a loss of meaning or direction, or who are attempting to cope with sudden and dramatic changes in a variety of professional or personal circumstances. Similarly, those clients who enter a foreign culture or who are members of a minority group within a dominant organizational or cultural ethos may find existential coaching to be of particular worth.

In general, those clients who value the reflective, exploratory and challenging qualities of existential coaching are likely to most benefit from it. It is equally likely, however, that some clients will struggle with its emphasis on descriptive exploration rather than prescriptive change or goal-setting.

EVALUATION OF EXISTENTIAL COACHING

Overall, existential coaching's emphasis on 'being qualities' and meaning exploration, as opposed to the development and refinement of the coach's 'doing' skills and repertoire, runs counter to current dominant assumptions and emphases within coaching as a whole. Whether this divergence will eventually prove to be its greatest strength or weakness remains to be seen. Even so, while it is undoubtedly less focused upon providing the means for immediate shifts in specific behaviours and performance, its concern to extend clients' understanding of their stance to life and how this stance impacts upon their behaviour is as likely to provoke performance-focused change as is any other model of coaching.

What direct research evidence currently exists for the effectiveness of existential coaching is extremely limited. In part, this is likely due to the currently small number of coaches who have trained sufficiently to practise this approach. Equally, its philosophical assumptions reveal a decidedly different set of principles from those of dominant empirical models regarding what constitutes evidence and how such may be examined (Spinelli, 2005). Whether these principles can be 'translated' in order that they may be examined and tested within the criteria set by dominant perspectives also remains, as yet, uncertain.

Having said this, clients' self reports related to the outcomes associated with this approach are generally highly positive and emphasize the felt sense of a greater congruence with lived experience and through this, a greater clarity regarding aims, values and identity. Within the context of executive and transformational coaching, clients have reported improvements in managing complexity, ambiguity and anxiety as well as a greater degree of personal and inter-personal responsibility.

While it can stand as a model of coaching in its own right, the descriptive focus that is so central to existential enquiry can assist coaches from whatever orientation or model to consider more adequately and more clearly their own stance, and to recognize how they may be confused or uncertain about various basic principles or practices that their model espouses. In short, existential enquiry can assist both coaches and their clients in ‘owning’ their experiences, approach, values and beliefs so that their concerns can be more adequately explored.

Some coaches have argued that the existential perspective emphasizes a self-serving individualism that might damage both individuals and organizations (Peltier, 2001). As this chapter has sought to highlight, this view is a serious misreading of existential theory in that it distorts one of its key principles. Rather than foster an individualistic ethos that separates self from others, or the client from his or her life and work conditions and relations, the existential approach asserts the necessity to acknowledge and place oneself in an interrelational context. In coaching, this relational perspective emerges in various ways, such as the encouragement of a stance toward responsibility that is relationally-attuned rather than solely individually focused.

Following on from this last point, it is the view of the present author that in locating itself within a predominantly organizational context, coaching (however unwillingly or inadvertently) is also adopting a relationally-attuned or interrelational perspective akin to that which lies at the heart of existential thought and practice. While an increasing number of coaches and coaching trainers have sought to demonstrate that it is this very same interrelational assumption that provides a baseline grounding in the clarification, challenge and attempted resolution of the issues being brought by coaching clients (Sieler, 2003), the revolutionary impact of this perspective has not yet been sufficiently addressed nor considered. Existential coaching is currently at the forefront of such explorations and, in the long term, this may well turn out to be its most significant contribution to the advancement of the coaching profession.

FURTHER READING

There exists, at present, very little literature on existential coaching – a situation that hopefully will be rectified in the near future. However, many of the central ideas and practices that would inform existential coaching have been elaborated in writings dealing with existential psychology and therapy. Among these, I would recommend the following to interested readers:

Jacobsen, B. (2007). *Invitation to existential psychology*. Chichester: Wiley.

Spinelli, E. (1997). *Tales of un-knowing: therapeutic encounters from an existential perspective*. London: Duckworth.

Spinelli, E. (2007). *Practising existential psychotherapy: The relational world*. London: Sage.

van Deurzen, E. (2001). *Existential counselling and psychotherapy in practice*. London: Sage.

Yalom, I. (1980). *Existential psychotherapy*. New York: Basic Books.

These texts have been noted by reviewers as particularly clear and accessible accounts of existential theory. In addition, all provide examples from general life and professional practice to which many coaches can connect both personally and professionally.

As well as the above, I would highlight three books in particular which, while not strictly within the existential tradition, address similar views and concerns within a specific coaching context.

Bluckert, P. (2006). *Psychological dimensions of executive coaching*. Berkshire: Open University Press.

Senge, P., Scharmer, C.O., Jaworski, J., & Flowers, B.S. (2005). *Presence: An exploration of profound change in people, organizations, and society*. New York: Currency.

Sieler, A. (2003). *Coaching to the human soul: Ontological coaching and deep change*. Blackburn, Victoria: Newfield Australia.

Peter Bluckert's writings are informed by the Gestalt tradition and emphasize the critical significance of the coaching relationship itself. Alan Sieler's advocacy of a being-focused (ontological) approach to coaching raises numerous perspectives that resonate with existential theory and practice. His focus on embodiment is particularly relevant. Peter Senge and his associates have produced an exceptional and eloquent text that should be read by all coaches. Their idea of *Presence* – that is to say, the interconnectedness between the whole and its parts and the influences of change in the latter upon the former – addresses a crucial existential theme in a manner that is particularly relevant and accessible to coaches.

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Spinelli, E. (2007). *Practising existential psychotherapy: The relational world*. London: Sage.

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